So, Singh Deo has been inducted into the party's central election committee, and Priyanka Gandhi attended two rallies in Rajasthan in locations where Pilot wields considerable influence, indicating the family's support to him.

Having put their house in order, Kharge and Rahul Gandhi have allowed state satraps to manage the campaigns while the Congress high command keeps an eye on them through trusted election strategists. The key ones are Sunil Kanungo, former colleague of Prashant Kishor and an architect of the party's Karnataka victory; Shashi Kant Senthil, former IAS officer-turned-party member, who had teamed up with Kanungo for the Karnataka polls; and Naresh Arora, whose firm DesignBoxed oversaw Shivakumar's campaign in Karnataka. While Senthil has been assigned Rajasthan, Kanungo is responsible for both Rajasthan and MP. Another member of the Karnataka campaign, general secretary in-charge of the state Randeep Singh Surjewala, will play the same role in MP.

The BJP, on the other hand, is fighting the state polls in Modi's name rather than repose trust in the incumbent state leadership, even as it talks of the merits of a double-engine sarkar. In support of that slogan, Modi wrote a letter to the people of MP on October 19, saying their vote will work as "direct support" to him at the Centre. In the past year, Modi has visited these three states over a dozen times. He has inaugurated or laid foundation stones for several projects, and used the occasions to interact with party members, even addressing booth-level party workers.

The BJP has also fielded 21 MPs, including three Union ministers. In Madhya Pradesh, where eight MPs are in fray, Union minister Narender Singh Tomar, a candidate himself and campaign committee chief, is breathing down Chouhan's neck as are other CM aspirants such as Union ministers Faggan Singh Kulaste and Prahlad Patel, state minister Narottam Mishra and national general secretary Kailash Vijayvargiya.

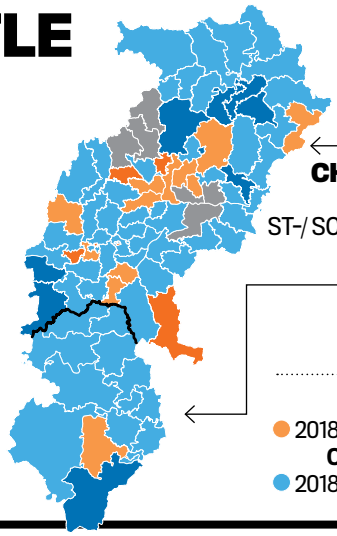
In Rajasthan, Raje, who is not even part of any poll committee, is facing a challenge more from party colleagues like Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat and Rajya Sabha MP Kirodi Lal Meena than from the Gehlot-led Congress. Several BJP insiders also see the decision to field Lok Sabha MP and Jaipur royal Diya Kumari as a strategy to groom another royal to counter the influence of Raje, the tallest BJP leader in the state, going by the crowds in her rallies.

In Chhattisgarh, the BJP signalled a generational shift last year when it appointed the 54-year-old first-time MP Sao as state chief. In another reshuffle, Narayan Chandel took over from Dharamlal Kaushik as leader of the Opposition. While he is being touted as Raman Singh's successor, the candidature of Renuka Singh Saruta, the Union minister of state for tribal affairs, has complicated matters.

To avoid repeating the mistakes of Karnataka and Himachal, where internal feuds damaged the party's prospects, the national leadership is keeping a tight leash on state affairs without letting any one faction flex its muscle. If Raje has been denied charge of the Rajasthan campaign, the party has also replaced the overambitious state president Satish Poonia, whose running feud with Raje was a constant headache, with low-profile Chittorgarh MP C.P. Joshi, a close aide of home minister Shah. Similarly in Chhattisgarh, Modi-Shah confidant Om Mathur has been made election in-charge.

THE BATTLE GROUND

THERE ARE 9 SEATS IN CHHATTISGARH, INCLUDING 2 RESERVED FOR STs, THAT HAVE GONE IN THE CONGRESS'S KITTY IN THE PAST 3 ELECTIONS. THE BJP HAS 6 SIMILAR STRONGHOLDS, WHICH INCLUDE AN SC AND ST SEAT EACH

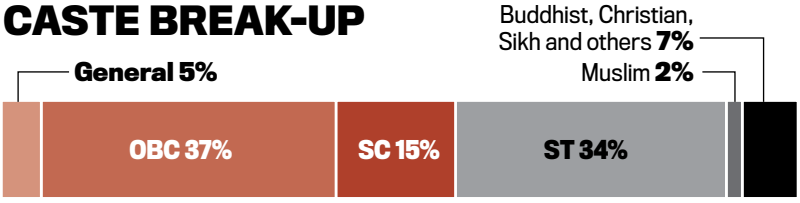


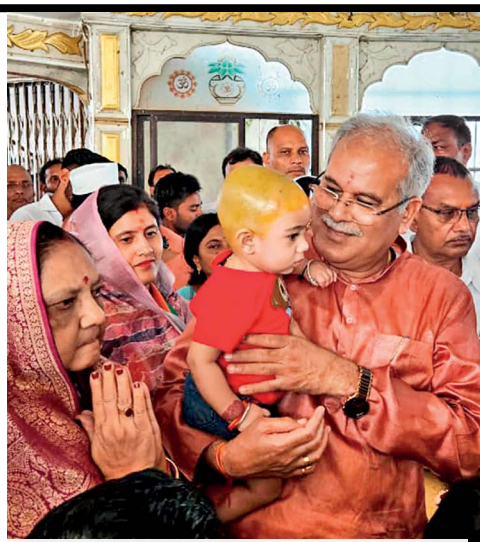
REST OF CHHATTISGARH
78 constituencies
ST-/ SC-/ OBC-dominated

BASTAR
12 constituencies
ST-dominated

BJP won in...
2018 past 3 elections
Congress won in...
2018 past 3 elections

CASTE BREAK-UP





FRIENDS & FAMILY Chhattisgarh CM holds his grandson at a temple in Dongargarh, Oct. 17; (right) home minister Amit Shah with ex-CM Raman Singh at a BJP event in Rajnandgaon, Oct. 16